A THAW STARTS IN SRINAGAR
PG 9

VIZAG: A CAPITAL GETS READY
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UPFRONT

BIHAR: NITISH TO THE FORE
PG 13

MP: BJP PULLS OUT THE BIG GUNS
PG 16



AFTER A CLEAN BREAK
AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami (centre) with party leaders at a meeting in Chennai, Sept. 26

ANI

TAMIL NADU

DIVORCE OF CONVENIENCE

By Amarnath K. Menon

By now, the spectacle of long-time partners making for the exit door is no longer a novel one for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)—the undivided Shiv Sena in 2019 and the Shiromani Akali Dal in 2020 are the oft-cited cases that ended in an acrimonious divorce. When the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) joined that list on September 25, it was not entirely unexpected either. Relations between the BJP and its most influential National Democratic Alliance (NDA) partner in the south had started to fray ever since K. Annamalai took over as the saffron party's Tamil Nadu president in July 2021. The strident 39-year-old, a 2011 batch Indian Police Service officer who resigned in 2019 to join politics, does not miss an opportunity to let loose some vocal pyrotechnics. His manner suited a party that, having largely had to play second fiddle to the AIADMK for years, didn't seem to mind a spot of overcorrection—even if it meant angering its old friend.

Annamalai believes the BJP has to go it alone in Tamil Nadu if it wants